

The effects of colonization

European countries had colonized the Americas, Africa, and Asia to secure power, generate wealth, and create a global trade in cotton, tobacco, and sugar. They enslaved millions of people and oppressed millions more, suppressing local cultures and traditions in the process. The effects of the colonial era can still be felt around the world today.

In the 18th and 19th centuries, powerful European nations, such as France and Britain, continued to expand their territory by invading and colonizing other countries, until by the end of the 19th century their empires included most of Africa, India, Southeast Asia, Australia, and the Pacific Islands. In most colonies, people were forced to convert to Christianity, their rights and ways of life came under attack, and they were exploited and poorly paid, or sold into slavery. Although European

powers eventually withdrew or were ousted from the majority of their colonies by the late 20th century, this period of colonialism has had a lasting impact on colonized people, lands, and cultures. European nations are only now starting to fully face the cruelty of their colonial past.



▲ LOSS OF INDIGENOUS BELIEFS

European colonizers believed that Christianity was the “true religion.” They used their Christian faith to justify claiming land from nonbelievers, taking over from local rulers and exploiting their people. Many Indigenous people were forced to convert to Christianity. These Papuans from New Guinea are burning objects of worship important to their old religion.

SAMUEL MAHARERO

Namibian hero Samuel Maharero (1856–1923) was Paramount Chief of the Herero people. When German colonizers began shooting his people for rebelling against their rule, Maharero bravely led around 1,000 people to safety.

